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'Get The Flock Out': The Fight Over License-Plate Readers Heats Up

The debate over Flock Safety's license plate readers heats up in the Bay Area and beyond.

Jul 8, 2026 Updated Jul 22, 2026

By [Morgan Sung](#), [Maya Cueva](#), [Chris Egusa](#), [Chris Hambrick](#)









Protesters advocating against Flock Safety cameras are surrounded by images of automated license plate readers. (Composite image by Maya Cueva and Chris Egusa; Images courtesy of Gustavo Hernandez via KQED, Tony Webster via Wikimedia Commons)

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Flock Safety's license plate readers have become a flashpoint for a debate across the country. On one side: law enforcement and their supporters, who say the cameras reduce crime and improve public safety. On the other: civil liberties advocates who argue that the cameras are a surveillance overreach. Morgan talks to Bay Area reporters Roselyn Romero and Riley Cooke about the fight over Flock spreading throughout the region, what we still don't know about how Flock's data is used and how it's being challenged.



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- [Riley Cooke](#), reporter at *Palo Alto Weekly*

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Episode Transcript

This is a computer-generated transcript. While our team has reviewed it, there may be errors.

Bay Area Resident: Having Flock cameras will not keep us safe. These cameras will go up in the neighborhoods where people of color live and we can be damn sure that this information will

Morgan Sung: In April, Bay Area residents crowded into the downtown Oakland Administration building. It was supposed to be a routine budget meeting for the Alameda County Board of Supervisors.

This would allow the controversial surveillance tech company to continue running its network of AI-powered license plate readers throughout the county — including unincorporated areas outside the county.

The room was packed with residents, from Oakland to Castro Valley. Even more attended virtually to give comments. More than a hundred residents spoke during the meeting. [Close All Tabs](#)

Narayan: Good evening. I urge you to reject Flock's \$854,000 contract extension. This isn't a camera system, it's a mass surveillance network that will track every single one of us, making a surveillance state.

Morgan Sung: Flock's license plate readers have become a flashpoint for a debate across the country — not just in the Bay Area. On one side: law enforcement and their supporters, who say they're keeping neighborhoods safe. On the other: residents who say they're invading privacy. And some aren't even able to vote yet.

Narayan: Hi, my name's Narayan. I'm 17. I go by he/him pronouns, and I'm from East Oakland.

Kaylyn: Hello, my names Kaylyn. I'm 17 years old, and I live in Oakland.

Tyson: My name is Tyson, I'm 18, he/him pronouns, and I live in Albany.

Narayan: I'm here to stop the implementation and extending of a Flock contract in my county. Flock is a multi-billion dollar corporation that is focused on hyper surveillance of people, and it's not safe.

Morgan Sung: Three years ago, Alameda County leaders approved a contract to install 100 plate readers throughout the county. Berkeley has just over 30, and Oakland recently approved a contract for 100.

Manny: I've been fighting Flock since 2023, but now it's a lot more in the cultural zeitgeist. A lot of people have become a lot aware of the surveillance systems that are being used to surveil the community.

Ramesh Sridharan: We don't want mass surveillance. We should be investing in communities. We should be spending our money on that as opposed to programs like Flock, which contribute to the surveillance state.

Morgan Sung: But some residents spoke in support of extending Flock's contract.

Robert Battinich: I was raised in San Leandro for 25 years. I own property in San Leandro and I've been robbed 24 times. Recently, they put Flock cameras in San Leandro, and it seems to be a trend.

Ralph Brown: I mean, it seems like a majority of you are just ready to reject the overwhelming majority of your residents who are telling you to vote “no” on this contract, not spend \$300,000.

Morgan Sung: The meeting lasted hours — and after all that, the board of supervisors voted 3-2 in favor of extending the contract. Protests broke out.

[Protesters outside of budget meeting]: Get Flock off our block! Get Flock off our block! Get Flock off our block!

Morgan Sung: The backlash we’re seeing against Flock in Alameda County is part of a bigger nationwide fight against normalizing mass surveillance. Flock vandalism is up across the country.

[Clip from @wwmtnews on YouTube]: The Kalamazoo County Sheriff’s Office says someone intentionally cut down a Flock license plate reader camera along D Avenue in Cooper Town.

[Clip from @WHAS11News on YouTube]: Auburn normally has 12 in the city, now they’re down two.

[Clip from @tmj4 on YouTube]: Take a close look at this automatic license plate reading camera, and you’ll notice gold paint covering the lens.

Morgan Sung: People have put stickers over the cameras’ lenses, covered them with trash bags, paintbombed entire devices, and joked online about pointing lasers at the cameras to destroy them.

[Clip from @KEZI9News on YouTube]: No arrests have been made in either jurisdiction, but this is considered criminal mischief.

Morgan Sung: That’s local news station KEZI 9, which actually broadcasted the uncensored note. But aside from resorting to “criminal mischief,” how else are people fighting the installation of Flock?

This is Close All Tabs. I’m Morgan Sung, tech journalist, and your chronically online friend, here to open as many browser tabs as it takes to help you understand how the digital world affects your privacy.

Automated license plate readers, or ALPRs, have been rapidly rolled out by cities and communities around the country, with Flock Safety’s tech at the lead. Before we get any deeper into this, let’s get into the origin story.

So, Flock Safety is based in Atlanta, Georgia. It operates a whole host of surveillance devices: cameras, drones, and, importantly, for this story, ALPRs. Back in 2014, Garrett called up two of his college buddies. Together, they worked on a prototype camera that could record and share what he called “evidence,” not just footage. Here he is speaking to Forbes.

So, Garrett called up two of his college buddies. Together, they worked on a prototype camera that could record and share what he called “evidence,” not just footage. Here he is speaking to Forbes.

[Clip of Garrett’s interview with @Forbes on YouTube]: Yeah, it’s pretty wild. At the end of ’17, we were sitting at my dining room table in Atlanta, building cameras by hand. And now we’re selling them.

Morgan Sung: “Fun” is certainly one way to put it. This entrepreneurial, neighborly concern has grown into an operation of at least 90,000 cameras nationwide, scanning over 20 billion license plates a day.

In Oakland, the push for installing Flock’s ALPRs was fueled by local frustration over BIP-ing — you know, breaking into a parked car and looting whatever’s inside. Here’s Roselyn Romero, a former Oakland Police Officer, on the issue.

Roselyn Romero: BIP-ing, or car break-ins, were also understandably making a lot of residents angry.

Morgan Sung: The city took action around 2024.

Roselyn Romero: The Oakland Police Department eventually signed a contract with Flock Safety for cameras to be installed throughout the city, primarily on freeway entrances and exits. A lot of people were angry about that.

Morgan Sung: Flock’s ALPRs go way further than the standard traffic cam that tickets drivers for speeding. The cameras automatically capture the license plate of every car that drives by — and they also record the make and model of the car.

Roselyn Romero: The make and the model of that vehicle, if there is a scrape on the bumper, or if there are bumper stickers on the car — Flock keeps a database of all of that information of every car that drives by.

Morgan Sung: Flock will send officers alerts when a camera captures a vehicle that’s been marked stolen or wanted. Or, the police can search the database to trace a specific vehicle’s movements.

But whether Flock has any part in that is dubious. The city started cracking down on car break-ins long before it adopted Flock cameras. Still, supporters say that Flock is necessary to prevent crime.

Morgan Sung: All of the data collected by Flock cameras around the country is shared and stored in a massive aggregated database, which can be accessed by anyone in the network. That means both of these scenarios are real. They've already happened. Privacy activists and civil liberties groups are especially worried. Given the Trump administration's recent immigration crackdown.

Roselyn Romero: People are scared — even putting Flock cameras aside, many immigrants are afraid of immigration enforcement knocking on their doors. We're hearing a lot of newly arrived immigrants. We've been seeing reports of law enforcement agencies and police departments in places outside of California that have shared data with Border Patrol, with U.S. Customs and Immigration Enforcement. And so a lot of people are understandably afraid. And really concerned about, well, if this technology is continued here in Alameda County, who's to say that that data is gonna end up in the wrong hands?

Morgan Sung: A big part of the concern is around data privacy. Flock says it deletes all the information after 30 days. But the company isn't very transparent about how they handle all of this data.

Roselyn Romero: There have been a lot of concerns from community members I've interviewed who say, you know, even if this data is stored in this database for 30 days, what happens after 30 days?

Morgan Sung: Flock also says all of this data, and their camera feeds, are encrypted. These assurances fall flat, though. Around the U.S., amateur hackers have been able to get around the encryption.

[Clip from @BennJordan on YouTube]: You may remember me from this video, where I told you about 40,000 of these things that your tax dollars pay for that are tracking your every movement.

Morgan Sung: With the help of a cybersecurity expert, Benn was able to hack Flock safety cameras in a whopping 30 seconds.

[Clip from @BennJordan on YouTube]: First thing you're going to want to do is go ahead and press the button to turn on that police camera. Then press the button on the back a number of times.

Morgan Sung: Apparently, hacking a Flock camera really is that easy. At least, it was when that video was published. And once you're in, there's a lot you can do.

[Clip from @BennJordan on YouTube]: You can clone or decompile the apps. You could send the video stream data to a remote server. You could use it as a botnet client for malware. You could use it for anything.

Roselyn Romero: When these cameras can be hacked and used to spy on people or watch kids, watch everyday people, it really makes you think: how comfortable are we with this type of monitoring?

Morgan Sung: In a follow-up video, Benn showed how easy it was to find the control panels for Flock's cameras. 404 Media confirmed that at least 60 of Flock's Condor cameras — the ones that are used for law enforcement — can be hacked. So, if Flock cameras can be easily hacked or are left totally unsecured, what does it mean for the troves of data? All the photos, the live feeds, the vehicle fingerprints that are stored on Flock's servers.

Roselyn Romero: There have been a lot of red flags raised by privacy experts and technology experts who say that Flock doesn't have enough data privacy safeguards to protect itself from liability.

Morgan Sung: There have been reports of law enforcement using Flock data for both of these purposes — as well as more... personal uses.

Roselyn Romero: We've seen reports from other parts of the country where police officers have used Flock's database to track down their ex-girlfriends and stalk them.

Morgan Sung: A Wisconsin cop used Flock to stalk his ex-girlfriend and her partner. He submitted 179 database searches for their license plates. In fact, multiple officers have been accused of using Flock data for personal use.

Roselyn Romero: So, even though we have Flock and law enforcement saying one thing about Flock cameras' original intent and purpose, there's always the potential for something to happen.

Morgan Sung: And that's all assuming that technology is working correctly. What if Flock's vehicle fingerprint is wrong? Just a few months ago, police stopped a 62-year-old woman in Oakland.

Roselyn Romero: So, she exited the vehicle with her hands up, her car registration was in her hand, and she saw these sheriff's deputies pointing their guns at her — and she was really confused. And so, eventually the sheriff's deputies told her, "Oh, you might not be the suspect we're looking for because the license plate reader tracked down your license plate. And we essentially connect it to the database."

Roselyn Romero: She came to the realization, “I’m being treated like I’m a violent criminal.” That could have gone so much worse than it did, right?

Morgan Sung: But here’s the thing: Flock flagged a black Honda Civic. This woman drove a silver car. Flock’s “vehicle fingerprint” is supposed to be holistic, taking into account way more de

Roselyn Romero: It opens up this scary question of: can this happen to me? Can this happen to someone I love, someone I know — completely unsuspecting — who may have had their licer

Morgan Sung: And here’s another issue with this technology: racial bias. Black and Brown communities are already more likely to be overpoliced and are disproportionately targeted for traf

And as one study showed, Flock Safety cameras have been found to surveil predominantly Black communities more intensely than white ones. In Virginia’s Hampton Roads area, neighborhoc

Roselyn Romero: In neighborhoods where Black and Brown people are already overly policed, overly surveilled, and overly criminalized, these cameras can play a big role in terms of the ty

Morgan Sung: And, the company has been long-resistant to efforts to track and log its devices, like in the case of a project called DeFlock. It’s an open-source, community-run tool that ident

[Clip of Garrett’s interview with @Forbes on YouTube]: Unfortunately, there’s terroristic organizations like DeFlock, whose primary motivation is chaos. They are closer to Antifa tha

Morgan Sung: That interview is from September of last year. A few months later, he sent an unsolicited email to all Flock law enforcement clients.

Roselyn Romero: And in that email, the CEO attacked activist groups who were against Flock. He said that they wanted to normalize lawlessness and let murderers go free. The CEO also ca

Morgan Sung: This prompted the city of Staunton, Virginia, as well as several others, to officially terminate their contracts.

Roselyn Romero: And in a press release, the police chief of Staunton, Virginia, basically was like, “We will not tolerate this type of rhetoric.” They said, quote, “The city of Staunton wants to

Morgan Sung: Langley’s comments also came amid intense debate over local police sharing Flock data with ICE, which is a violation of city policy in some places. Altogether, it was a PR dis

Despite all the vocal opposition, Flock has a lot of support from businesses looking to improve public safety around their buildings — whether it’s private companies trying to protect employee

Roselyn Romero: Flock Safety cameras have been used by many business leaders and commercial districts throughout the Bay Area to address crime, prevent crime, track down people who

Morgan Sung: But residents are becoming more vocal about their distrust in Flock — in part, because it’s unclear who exactly has access to Flock’s data once it’s collected.

Roselyn Romero: Who’s to say that these law enforcement agencies from other states can also use data from California law enforcement agencies?

Morgan Sung: How far is this data being shared? Is Flock breaking local laws? One reporter in Palo Alto uncovered a slew of Flock search requests that violated the city’s own policies. We’re

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Okay, we’re back. Let’s open a new tab: The Palo Alto Flock scandal.

Riley Cooke: People were just as fired up about a pickleball debate a couple of weeks ago in Palo Alto — so there are certain issues that definitely get people to turn out, whether it’s convertir

Morgan Sung: Riley Cooke is a City Hall reporter at Palo Alto Weekly. Earlier this year, a publication in nearby Mountain View had discovered that the city’s Flock data had been accessed by

Riley Cooke: So what I did is I filed a records request for these search audits that Flock and the police department maintain. So, every time a search is conducted, whether by a local officer o

Morgan Sung: The request was approved, but at first, the police chief didn’t hand over the specific documents that Riley was looking for.

Morgan Sung: The search records revealed that police departments from all over the country were also searching Palo Alto's Flock data, without the permission of the city, or the Palo Alto Police Department.

Riley Cooke: The police department told me that they didn't actually access any of the data or download it, but Palo Alto's cameras still appeared in search results from, you know, Mississippi and Texas.

Morgan Sung: ATF is short for the Bureau of Alcohol, Tobacco, Firearms, and Explosives. Riley's reporting shows that, for about a year and a half, tens of thousands of searches from outside the state were coming in.

Riley Cooke: I think my hope with doing that was to sort of beg the question of: what do these agencies have anything to do with Palo Alto? Or why is Palo Alto's ALPR data appearing in searches from these agencies?

Morgan Sung: This is actually super illegal. California law prohibits the sharing of ALPR data with out-of-state and federal agencies — and this has been the case since 2016. The Palo Alto Police Department was sharing it with the FBI.

Riley Cooke: And, they went above and beyond existing California law about not sharing with any out-of-state or federal agencies. And, what my reporting shows is that Flock was still able to share that data with the FBI.

I think city officials were really confident at first that they had enacted these protections, that they were protecting residents and heeding those surveillance concerns. And yet, at the end of the day, they were not.

Morgan Sung: It begs the question: why did Flock bypass the police department and make this data available nationwide? And what is the point of privacy protections if Flock can just access everything?

Riley Cooke: Recently there's been hundreds of people turning out to city government meetings to protest the Flock contract and urging Palo Alto to do what neighboring cities have done, which is to get rid of Flock.

Morgan Sung: Now, thanks to Riley's reporting, the Palo Alto Police Department is proactively sharing license plate search logs on its website.

Riley Cooke: So, everyone's able to go and find that information on their own, and can verify that no out-of-state or illegal searches are being performed. I don't know any other city that's currently doing that.

Morgan Sung: The consulting firm in charge of the Flock audit — called the OIR Group — has managed to hold Palo Alto's cops accountable in the past — like standardizing bodycam usage.

Riley Cooke: They don't like that they were lied to. And so, I think a lot of residents had their suspicions about this, couldn't exactly confirm that it was happening in Palo Alto, and my reporting helped confirm that.

Morgan Sung: Riley said the Palo Alto Police Department will probably listen to resident demands for greater transparency around Flock. But, even if the city gets rid of Flock cameras, law enforcement is still using other surveillance tools.

We're heading back to Alameda County, where Oakland is partnering with Flock to operate nearly 300 ALPRs throughout the city. But organizers remain committed to protesting the contract.

Roselyn Romero: Because of Alameda County's location, situated where all of these technological and AI advancements are originated, and the fact that Alameda County is home to many social justice movements, racial justice movements, and activists are also on the side of: we shouldn't have Flock in our communities, and why are we continuing to expand these technologies?

So I think it speaks to this crucial moment in Alameda County of: everybody agrees that Flock Safety's cameras are really powerful. It's just- now, the debate is: what to use that power for, how to use it.

Morgan Sung: In California, organizers have actually made real progress in stopping Flock — or getting it removed. Santa Cruz was the first city to turn off its cameras. Mountain View, South San Francisco, and San Jose have also removed Flock.

Roselyn Romero: In Oakland, we've seen people paintbombing these Flock cameras, where cameras in Oakland have just been splashed with paint and vandalized, if you will.

Morgan Sung: And beyond the concerns about Flock's capabilities, the company's services are expensive. Flock contracts add up to millions of dollars. And this has many residents questioning the value.

Roselyn Romero: When crime is at near historic lows, why are we continuing to put more money and more power into these powerful technologies? Right now, the Oakland City Council is considering a referendum to get rid of Flock.

A lot of community members are saying, "Why are we continuing to invest in police technologies and surveillance tools when we could instead allocate that money toward, say, health care or education?"

It's a really interesting and seemingly endless debate that we're seeing in Oakland and Alameda County and across the country.

Morgan Sung: Back in April, at the Alameda Board of Supervisors meeting, the board voted in favor of extending the Flock contract until July 1st. That's despite the vocal pushback from residents.

[Protesters outside of budget meeting]: Get Flock off our block! Get Flock off our block! Get Flock off our block!

Morgan Sung: Last Tuesday — the day before the contract expired — the Alameda Board of Supervisors once again voted to extend Flock's contract... This time, until the end of next year.

Alameda County Supervisor David Haubert: So that motion passes. We're not entertaining comments from the gallery.

Morgan Sung: Once that's up, the County Sheriff's Office will have the opportunity to look for alternative vendors: surveillance tech companies that offer the same services as Flock. There are a lot of them out there. So, even if the board votes to end its contract, this larger question still exists: Does mass surveillance of people who aren't suspected of a crime violate their Fourth Amendment right to privacy?

Roselyn Romero: This debate is not unique to the Bay Area. We're seeing — at the federal level — President Donald Trump's mass deportation agenda playing out in full force. What does that mean for us?

Morgan Sung: This debate gets at the heart of the right to privacy, guaranteed by the Constitution, but chipped away at every year. Communities across the country have made it clear that they want to protect their privacy.

That's it for today's deep dive. But, as usual, stick around after the credits for bonus content. And if you're dying to open more tabs about Flock Safety and all of its controversies, check out our

Close All Tabs is a production of KQED Studios, and it's reported and hosted by me, Morgan Sung. This episode was produced and field-reported by Maya Cueva. It was edited by Chris Egusa,

Audience and engagement support from Maha Sanad. Jen Chien is our Director of Podcasts and Ethan Toven-Lindsey is our Editor-in-Chief. Some members of the KQED Podcast team are

This episode's keyboard sounds were submitted by Alex Tran and recorded on his white Epomaker Hi75 keyboard with Fogruaden red samurai keycaps and materon Milky yellow pro v2 switches.

This episode includes clips from WWMT News, WHAS-11, TMJ4 News, KEZI 9, Benn Jordan, and Forbes. Special thanks to Rosalyn Romero and Riley Cooke, and everyone we spoke to at the

Riley Cooke: For the past couple of months, it's mostly been organized demonstrations, and there's been a sign that's been going around that says, "GTFO: Get the Flock Out," which I think is pretty accurate.

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